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PAKISTAN PRESIDENT ASIF ALI ZARDARI WITH ARMY CHIEF ASHFAQ PARVEZ KAYANI

rhetoric, as it initially did, it gave the Pakistan Army an excuse to start moving 1,00,000 soldiers from the Afghan front and pitting them against India. That would also see the people bind strongly behind the army marginalising the new democratic coalitions holding power. It would propel to the forefront Pakistan Army Chief General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani who could even stage a bloodless coup, if he so decided. It would also unite the country against a common enemy and hopefully the separatists and sectarian forces would cool down.

The Pakistan Army operates with such brazen confidence because it knows that India would hesitate to use the military option because of the nuclear shadow. In the midst of the gravest provocation following the border intrusions in the

Kargil sector, India chose to fight a limited war to evict the intruders from the heights rather than launch an assault on its Western borders. Even after the attack on Parliament in 2001, India hesitated although it launched Operation Parakram—the largest ever military build-up on the borders. After a 10-month stand off, India and its prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee backed off and resumed peace talks with Pakistan.

Nor has coercive diplomacy borne much fruit. After the Parliament attacks, to avoid a conflict with India, Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf promised to rein in the jihadis. But within months, they resumed operations under different names. Only now they began targeting Musharraf too. In 2002, India had broken off

## That Déjà Vu Feeling

The standoffs between India and Pakistan ended with diplomatic truce

**2001** After the attack on the Indian Parliament by Pakistan-based terrorists India mounted its biggest ever deployment of forces against Pakistan known as Operation Parakram, which ended after 10 months when the US made Pakistan to take some cosmetic measures to check cross border terrorism.

**Outcome** The standoff cost India Rs 6,500 crore and Pakistan Rs 4,500 crore. While the exercise was aimed at putting diplomatic pressure on Pakistan, it failed to achieve its purpose.

**1999** India launched operation Vijay to drive out Pakistani troops camouflaged as militants that had intruded into Indian territory.

**Outcome** As the threat of escalation grew and with clinching evidence that Pakistani regulars were involved, the US summoned Pakistani prime minister Nawaz Sharif to Washington and asked him to withdraw the infiltrating forces.



**1990** India and Pakistan engaged in an intense crisis over the growing terrorism in Kashmir. While Islamabad stepped up its support to militants, temperatures rose, and the Indian and Pakistani militaries were partially mobilised amid nuclear threats from Pakistan.

**Outcome** The two sides backed off following the twin restraints of nuclear deterrence and the US intervention.

**1987** The Brass Tacks military exercise by India nearly sparked a war with Pakistan boasting of its nuclear capabilities.

**Outcome** As tensions increased the hot line between the two countries was activated. In February 1987, Pakistan's President General Zia ul Haq travelled to India, under the pretense of watching a cricket match, where he held talks with the Indian leadership to diffuse the crisis.